

Slovenia

 Historically and geographically, Slovenia has more in common with Austria than with other neighbouring states. The country was ruled by Austria for almost a thousand years. Slovenia has many small farms and thriving businesses. Despite economic problems caused by the conflict in areas to the south, it is the region's wealthiest country.



Resources

Slovenia mines mercury, lead, oil, and zinc for export. There are also deposits of brown coal and lignite, but they are poor quality and difficult to extract. One-third of the country's energy comes from a nuclear plant in Krsvo.

Mercury ore



People

About 90 per cent of the population are Slovenes who have kept their language and traditional culture despite centuries of Austrian domination. Wages are higher than in other Balkan states, and standards of education are high. One in seven Slovenes lives in the capital, Ljubljana, which has textile, electronics, chemical, and manufacturing industries.

Tourism

Slovenia is slowly rebuilding its tourist industry, which suffered as a result of the war in Bosnia. Skiing, spa resorts, and lakeside scenery attract many visitors to the Alps in the north of the region.

Lake Bled is a popular tourist destination.

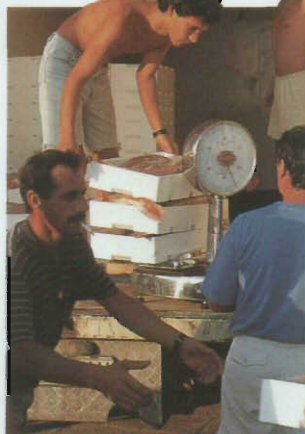
SLOVENIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Ljubljana
AREA	20,250 sq km (7,820 sq miles)
POPULATION	2,016,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Slovene
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Tolar



Croatia

 Ruled by Hungary for more than 800 years, Croatia became part of Yugoslavia in 1918, gaining independence in 1991. Croatia's economy was damaged by the war with neighbouring Bosnia, but it is fortunate in having important ports and rich resources, including oil, coal, and bauxite. The tourist industry is recovering.



Adriatic coast

Croatia's Adriatic coast has sandy beaches and hundreds of offshore islands that once attracted up to 12 million tourists every year. However, the outbreak of war in 1991 abruptly halted all tourism. The country still has a thriving fishing industry, with an annual catch of about 25,000 tonnes (27,500 tons).

Flax stalks

Zagreb

The cultural and industrial capital of Croatia is Zagreb, which grew out of two medieval settlements on the River Sava. The city has museums, art galleries, 13th-century buildings, and cathedrals, such as St Mark's and St Stephen's. Most people travel around by tram and bus.

CROATIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Zagreb
AREA	56,540 sq km (21,830 sq miles)
POPULATION	4,500,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Croatian
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian
CURRENCY	Kuna



Linen fibre

Flax

Fields of flax are cultivated in the fertile river valleys of northern Croatia. Flax fibre, which is obtained by crushing the stalks of the plant, is woven into linen and canvas, and its seeds yield linseed oil. Apricots, grapes, and plums are also grown in northern Croatia.

Bosnia and Herzegovina

 In 1991, bitter fighting broke out in the twin states of Bosnia and Herzegovina between the Roman Catholic Croats, Muslim Bosnians, and Orthodox Serbs. In all, about 300,000 people were killed, more than 2,000,000 fled the country, and many historic cities were devastated. A delicate peace has prevailed since 1995.



Muslims

During the war, Serbs from Bosnia forced Croats and Muslims out of areas they regarded as their own. Thousands were killed, and many Muslims fled abroad. In 1995, a peace agreement split the country into two provinces: Bosnian-Serb and Muslim-Croat.



Sarajevo

Straddling the River Miljacka, Sarajevo is the capital of Bosnia and Herzegovina. Under communist rule the city was transformed from a sleepy, Islamic town to a bustling, multi-cultural industrial centre. During the civil war, however, it was shattered by 2,000,000 shells, which killed tens of thousands of people. Serbs attacking the city were forced to withdraw in 1995.

BOSNIA AND HERZEGOVINA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Sarajevo
AREA	51,130 sq km (19,741 sq miles)
POPULATION	4,000,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Serbo-Croat
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, Muslim
CURRENCY	Markar

Farming

Bosnia and Herzegovina's main farming region lies in the southwest. The area has fertile, well-watered soil and hot, dry summers. Crops include citrus fruit, grapes, maize, pomegranates, figs, olives, rice, and tobacco. Sheep are reared on the upland areas.



Figs

Pomegranates